

ANI

**STANDING FOR JOINTNESS**
From left, CDS Gen Anil Chauhan, Chief of Air Staff Air Chief Marshal V.R. Chaudhari, Chief of Army Staff Gen Manoj Pande, Chief of Naval Staff Adml R. Hari Kumar

COME INDIA'S 77TH INDEPENDENCE DAY, AND Prime Minister Narendra Modi may yet make a long-awaited announcement when he addresses the nation from the ramparts of the Red Fort—the theatrisation of the Indian armed forces. Based on the doctrine of One Border, One Force, units of the army, navy and air force will be integrated over a certain geographic area, or theatre, under a single commander, with logistics, training and support services all woven into this single unit for optimum utilisation of military resources, operational efficiency and jointness in operations. General Bipin Rawat, India's first Chief of Defence Staff, had set the ball rolling, but his untimely death as well as opposition from the services, especially the Indian Air Force (IAF), had put the project on the back-burner. Current CDS Gen. Anil Chauhan has given it fresh impetus, and misgivings of the IAF have also been resolved.

Currently, the three services function with 17 independent commands: the army and air force have seven commands each, and the navy three. India did create a unified command in 2001, with the Port Blair-based Andaman and Nicobar Command. The Strategic Forces Command, in charge of the country's nuclear forces, also functions as a tri-services command.

Theatre commands were recommended by the Kargil review committee in 2000 to promote increased jointness between the three services. As per Gen. Rawat's original plan in 2020, there were to be five theatre commands—Eastern, Western, Peninsular, Maritime and an Air Defence Command. Two functional commands—Joint Training Command and Operational Logistics Command—were also planned. Now, however, the Indian military will be restructured into three integrated theatre commands. There will be two land-based commands—one focused on Pakistan and the other on China—and a third maritime one, overseeing the Indian Ocean Region.

CDS Chauhan has termed theatrisation as a most ambitious, 'fundamental' and significant military reform with far-reaching implications. On August 4, the Lok Sabha passed the Inter-Services Organisations (Command, Control and Discipline) Bill, 2023, which sought to empower the Centre to notify the setting up of theatre commands. It was passed in the Rajya Sabha on August 8. Efforts are now on to get an initial nod from the office of the minister of defence, claims a senior South Block official, before PM Modi makes an announcement. "Sincere efforts are being done at the headquarters of the Integrated Defence Staff to give final shape to the proposal," he says.

## Why Theatre Commands?

Much has changed in terms of technology, threat patterns and warfighting since 1971, when India fought its last major conventional war. The main threat is now from a superior adversary, China, which works in collusion with Pakistan. A two-front war is, therefore, a distinct possibility for India. More generally, the prospect of high technology, multi-domain warfare where adversaries are nuclear-armed requires a swift and dynamic response. The deft management of the escalation ladder across military and non-military verticals needs a theatre commander—a single authority to coordinate inter-service plans in real time. Integrated theatre commands will provide this capability. Likewise, the integrated theatre command plan envisages the creation of a Pakistan-centric Western Theatre Command stretching from Indira Col on Saltoro Ridge in the Siachen Glacier to Gujarat, with